Beckoning to Break the Seal

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48332845.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra)

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Canon Universe, Alternative Universe – Canon Divergence, Growing Up Together, Action, One Shot, Teenagers, Dealing with Impending Destiny, the Catradora is just a dash of yearning here, POV Catra (She-Ra)

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Part 1 of Children of the Crystal - Light Hope's Kids AU

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Summary

Years after Adora talked Light Hope into taking Catra in, theyŕe finally getting their first mission. Catra has watched Adora be raised for greatness for years, but now she's the only one who can do what Light Hope needs: save She-ra from the Horde. (Or, Light Hope succeeded in securing Adora after she brought her to Etheria, and now it's finally time to secure the sword)

Notes

This is the first fic in an AU series with a little bit of a different style than I have done before. These are all small fics with (mostly) self-contained moments set in the same canon-divergent universe, in a similar style that my Outside of the War series is for canon ideas. I wont tread on ƥlot”too much because it mirrors the show mostly (at least once the timeline reaches that point), but Ill hit some big points that diverge (like this one).
Theyŕe roughly tweens in this (think that one flashback of them training in the Horde's holodeck). This series is nonlinear and will be bouncing around a lot.

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra careens around a corner, ducking out of Adora's sight, and does something she's *really* not supposed to: she slides out her claws and digs them into the wall, scaling it as quickly as she can. Tiny cracks splinter out as her claws puncture into the crystalline walls of the castle, but Adora's panting will cover those sounds and Catra is quick. She reaches the ceiling and clambers onto a support beam before Adora can turn the corner and catch her. Catra has just barely managed to curl up, hopefully out of sight, when Adora's feet come pounding around the corner.

She keeps running, not noticing the small cracks in the wall. Hopefully Light Hope won't either. Catra does her best to snicker to herself silently as Adora with her dumb First One senses runs right past her. Catra quietly shuffles on the beam so she can peek over and watch Adora's ponytail bounce as she continues down the hallway, her footsteps slowing as she realizes that even Catra's superior speed shouldn't have taken her out of sight completely. Adora slows to a stop, panting, and looks like she's about to turn around, so Catra quickly shuffles back, hoping the height of the beam and its thickness will keep Adora from noticing her.

Catra listens closely, trying to control her breathing so she can hear which direction Adora turns.

Instead, she hears the subtle electric hum that often accompanies Light Hope's hologram appearing.

"Adora," and there it is. Adora startles – from the sound of it, so hard she almost falls over.

"Light Hope! Hi!" Adora says, sounding caught even though they weren't doing anything *wrong*. Sure, Catra just broke pretty much the biggest rule by using her claws on the castle, but Adora shouldn't know that. Maybe she spotted the cracks right before Light Hope appeared.

"I must speak with you and Catra," Light Hope says, in that so-direct-it's-urgent way she often uses to issue commands. Catra's ears and tail twitch. That could mean *I need to lecture you for being hooligans* – a new word Catra learned the last time she and Adora went tearing through a village in the woods playing, one she now loves – or *it's time for routine training* or *the Horde is quickly approaching the castle*.

"Oh, um, funny thing about that... I kind of lost her," Adora finally admits. Catra almost laughs and manages to stifle it down to a tiny snort. She thinks it's possible Adora would miss that sound.

"She is directly above you." Apparently a *hologram* with a ton of creepy sensors throughout the castle won't, though. Catra reluctantly unfurls, peeking over the edge of the beam to find Adora craning her head back to stare up at her. A smile breaks on Adora's face as they make eye contact, so Catra finds one of her own spreading as well.

"Being on the same level would facilitate conversation. This is important. There is no room for error," Light Hope interrupts. Catra and Adora exchange a quick look before Catra carefully leaps down. She lands beside Adora, straightening up and doing her best to stand tall beside Adora and Light Hope. She always feels so short when they all stand like this. Light Hope is still much taller than Adora, but Adora gained a few inches recently and Catra is feeling especially small.

"What's up, Nightlight?" Catra asks, flashing Light Hope a grin as Light Hope inclines her head down to look at her. She gives Catra a dead expression, completely unimpressed, before looking back between them. That's pretty much what Catra wanted. It's not often you get anything better out of Light Hope.

"I have a mission for you." Immediately, Catra and Adora both stand at attention. Catra's ears quiver with anticipation, but then she remembers what their last "mission" was.

"You're not going to send us crawling through the vents to manually reset something again, are you?" Catra asks, suspiciously. They didn't even leave the *castle*. They've trained against each other and Light Hope's holograms for years, but so far they have only gotten "responsibilities" that were something relatively mundane a hologram couldn't do. Like vent crawling.

"No. This will be the most important thing you do until it is time for Adora to take on She-ra's mantle," Light Hope says. Catra exchanges a glance with Adora, an anxious excitement passing between them.

"What is it?" Adora asks, a bit breathless. Light Hope sweeps her hand to the side, turning to summon a flickering image beside her. An image they both know well by now.

The sword.

Light Hope has never told them where it is. They've searched every inch of the castle for it at this point. They're still finding new abandoned passageways to this day, the low-power state the Crystal Castle is running in leaving some sections lifeless and dusty, but for something so important, it seems like they would have found signs of it so far.

There's also how afraid Light Hope seems to be of it falling into enemy hands. Catra concluded years ago that it isn't here, but Adora thinks that somehow Light Hope is still hiding it – "in an obvious place so we won't look," as if they haven't already *checked* the obvious places – because she thinks there's no way Light Hope would have left it anywhere vulnerable for so long. Catra doesn't think it matters what she wants. Light Hope used pretty much all the guardians she had bringing Adora back to the castle when she screwed up her portal and opened it in a field.

"Adora, you are still too young to safely bear the power of She-ra, but the Horde has been testing methods of breaching the woods. We cannot risk them succeeding," Light Hope says as the sword

projection lowers until the blade artificially appears to bury its tip in the ground, tilting slightly. Slowly, projected vines grow around its base.

"It's in the woods?" Adora asks, looking up at Light Hope with wide eyes. Catra's tail twitches. She *knew* she was right.

"Yes. Mara abandoned it there when she lost control," Light Hope verifies. Catra feels a prickle on the back of her scruff as Adora visibly dulls. The way Light Hope talks about the last She-ra always makes Adora anxious and Catra wary. She was too emotional, she couldn't take the pressure, they'll understand when they're older – only it has been *years* and Light Hope hasn't offered further clarity.

"The moment you touch the sword, your connection with She-ra will be forged and you will transform. We cannot risk potential consequences to becoming She-ra as a juvenile," Light Hope continues. Her head turns to Catra and Catra stands at attention again. "That is why Catra must be the one to retrieve it." Catra's hands curl in fists as she raises them up to her chin unconsciously, her tail waving with excitement.

"Really?" she asks, unashamed of the excitement in her voice. She has waited a long time to prove herself. Sure, she beats Adora in training as often as Adora beats her, but Catra is the normal one. No magic, no destiny or purpose. She's only still alive because Adora couldn't stand by when Light Hope picked up the magicat kingdom being slaughtered on her sensors. They didn't have any power to stop it, not with Adora so young, but Adora still tried. She's *Adora*. Catra has only been her training partner since then, not even the spare since only Adora can become She-ra.

Now, finally, there's something *important* that Catra can do and Adora can't.

"Is that dangerous?" Adora asks, reaching her hand over towards Catra without looking at her, as if to tell her to hold back. Catra scowls, but Light Hope shakes her head.

"It is too dangerous for you to come in physical contact with it, but it will not form a connection with a magicat. It won't be any more dangerous than carrying a regular sword for Catra," Light Hope says. Catra nudges Adora with her shoulder, throwing her grin.

"It's *my* turn to play with weapons," she says. Adora huffs, rolling her eyes. Really, Catra prefers her claws to any of the weapons Light Hope has available, but Adora usually trains with a sword in preparation for when she wields She-ra's.

"The two of you will go together. Adora, your job will be leading Catra through the woods and guarding her once she has secured the sword. Catra, you must find it and protect it with your life. The Horde should not be able to reach the sword right now, but that is why we must act before they draw closer," Light Hope instructs. Catra feels her fur stand on end at the words.

It's really happening. They have their first mission. Catra can prove herself, and after this, Adora will be one step closer to becoming She-ra. Soon they'll be allowed to go out and *fight*, to get back at the Horde for everything they've taken from them.

Well, from Catra, mostly. And she's going to be the one who gets to prove herself today.

--

The woods have always loved Adora. It's probably the only reason Adora managed to save Catra when they were little, the woods whisking them deep into its heart before they could be pursued. Now the woods let them wander and play freely, always bringing them home at the end of the day. Catra can run their paths as they cycle through their patterns, but she still sometimes gets lost. Either they don't like her claws digging into their bark or Adora really is that

special, because they don't part for Catra the way they seemingly do for Adora.

"Of course Light Hope couldn't give us anything to go on. We've run through these woods for years! How are we supposed to magically turn up something today that we've missed a thousand times?" Catra complains as she climbs onto a branch to get a better view out into the trees. Adora thinks methodically working through the woods as they shift is the best way to search for something new, but they've *been* everywhere in the pattern before, that's how they know it exists. They're better off charging straight into the darkness and hoping, but then they won't know what area they've searched that way if they clear it without finding anything, so Adora and her dumb map it is.

"The woods are big. Light Hope said the Horde is just testing breaching methods. We should have enough time to hunt it down. We know the woods better than they do," Adora assures, looking up from the map grid she has drawn of the different sections of the woods – that they know about, anyway. They could check most of them off right away, but like inside the Crystal Castle, there are always new undiscovered areas. Right now they're looking for one of those, but they've never successfully sought them out, they just *find* them.

Catra leaps down from the branch, having confirmed that yes, they've been here before, and they've seen a sword lying around.

"It could take us the rest of our *lives* to hunt it down this way. You've heard the people in Thaymor; no one has ever mapped the whole woods!" Catra protests, gesturing towards the path they've walked a hundred times. Adora gets that annoyed look on her face she gets when something she is set on gets challenged.

"What else do we do? We can't just run in a direction and hope," Adora returns. Catra's tail lashes as she crosses her arms and looks out at the trees. Right foliage eventually gives way to shadows in the distance.

"Do you think Razz might know something?" Catra asks, tail still twitching. The lady is *crazy*, but sometimes there's something useful in the ranting, coherence bleeding through from whatever she was like before she went senile. She taught Catra how to listen to the woods to navigate them, at least, so she doesn't have to leave trails of claw marks on tree trunks to mark her way anymore. It only worked half the time. Sometimes she would turn around and the woods had shifted completely behind her, all her markings gone. Sometimes she would walk into a trail she made weeks ago in the middle of an area she had never been to before.

The woods are *weird*, just like Razz. Adora looks up from her map, her eyes glimmering.

"You never know with Razz. It's worth trying, right? It doesn't take long to get to her," Adora agrees. Catra nods, vaguely. Adora rolls up her map, flashing Catra a grin. "Race you there?" she offers. Before Catra can agree, Adora takes off.

"Cheater!" Catra yells as she shoots off after her. Adora's laughter rings through the trees and Catra follows it. They can run headlong into darkness and it won't matter; as soon as they need Razz, the woods tend to bring them to her.

--

"Razz, you know Mara's sword?"

"Of course, dearie, you never put that thing down! You'd have more room to carry berries if you did."

"We think Mara *did* put it down. Have you seen it? Or do you know where she might have left it?" Adora is frustrated, like she often is when trying to get answers out of Razz. It's usually a lost cause.

Sometimes she happens to say something useful, and the rest of the time its nonsense. It still feels like less of a waste of time than Adora's plan.

Besides, this way Catra gets to steal pie while Razz is distracted with Adora. That always makes a visit to Razz worth it. Catra lurks behind the old woman, happily eating her fresh slice with a stolen fork. As weird as Razz is, she's a good cook. Way better than "meal replicator" back at the castle that Catra is pretty sure just mixes and reshapes the rations they put in it. The one time they tried to put in fresh fruit, it broke for a week. They went from enjoying any fruit or nuts they could find in the woods to relying on them while they waited for Light Hope to be able to manufacture the parts to fix it.

"Why are you asking questions you know the answer to?" Razz isn't so old she doesn't know a trick question when she hears one!" Razz chastises, brandishing her broom threateningly in Adora's direction. Adora sends Catra a frustrated look and Catra grins and gives her a thumbs up from over Razz's shoulder as she takes another bite of her pie.

"Because I need to find it before She-ra can fall into the Horde's hands. This is important," Adora tries. Catra snorts. Yeah, *important* has never meant shit to Razz. Adora should have just told her the sword was surrounded by berry bushes and Razz would have been motivated to hunt it down.

"But She-ra is right here!" Razz protests, gesturing at Adora. Adora pinches her brow.

"I'm not She-ra yet, Razz," Adora reminds. Catra finishes her slice of pie, looking up to find Razz staring at Adora, uncomprehending, through her giant glasses.

"Of course you are, dear. Who else would be She-ra?" Adora groans, throwing her head back to look up at the sky.

"Yeah, who else, Mara?" Catra teases, sidling up beside Razz. Razz gestures at Catra with her broom.

"See, Light Hope understands!"

Okay, that's just insulting.

--

"Well that was a waste of time," Adora mutters to herself as they walk back into the woods.

"Nuh uh, I got pie," Catra returns, flashing her a grin. Predictably, Adora pouts at her. There's indecision in her eyes as she glances back, like she might actually want to go back and get her own slice, but reluctantly she turns forward again and pulls out her map.

"Alright, what's the plan now? We're far from where we started. We need a new search vector or whatever," Catra asks, looking around. Adora looks up too, blinking at their surroundings.

Catra sees it too. Tall trees looming ahead of them, larger – older – than any that she has seen before. They wandered out of Razz's and right into the middle of nowhere. Catra draws to a halt, slowly turning on her heel and looking around. Behind them, she can't even see a glimpse of Razz's hut, and they've barely walked at all. Catra finishes her turn, meeting eyes with Adora. Adora's brow is furrowed, thoughts spinning behind her eyes. They both turn to look into the trees stretching before them.

"It led us to Razz," Catra reasons. Adora lowers her map.

"It always does. We've never seen the sword," she counters, but she doesn't really sound like she's arguing.

"That's because we've never looked for it before," Catra argues. Vaguely, Adora nods. She throws a glance to Catra, looking a little unsure.

"What if we just get lost?" Adora asks. Catra rolls her eyes.

"We've been lost before. Besides, we're together, and you know the woods will always take care of you. We'll be fine and make it home by curfew," Catra says. They don't actually have a curfew, or rather, their curfew is probably supposed to be all the time. Light Hope gave up on keeping them in the castle long ago and just insists they keep to the safe parts of the woods. It wouldn't matter what she says. For now, it seems like the woods themselves agrees with her and have never show them their edges in more than distant glances before they ended up somewhere deeper and safer.

Adora heaves a sigh, seeming to steel herself, and then nods.

"We're already here. Come on," she says. Finally, they're doing things *Catra's* way. She follows as Adora marches forward, brushing foliage aside. It's thick here, another sign of the age of this area.

Hopefully that's a good thing. The sword has been abandoned for a thousand years, right?

Wow, the Whispering Woods are *old*.

--

These aren't the woods they're used to. It has been a long time since Catra has felt anxious in the trees – especially when she is with Adora – but there's more to this area than just tall trees. Adora is trying to focus on the image of the sword Light Hope showed them and hoping the woods will understand her, but Catra is on guard for

both of them. As they walk, they begin to pass by plants she has never even seen before. Occasionally, the ground rumbles.

Catra looks down, watching a pebble shake on the ground as another low reverberation runs through the ground and up her spine, causing her fur to prickle. Adora clutches her map pensively. She is keeping her gaze locked forward, trying to concentrate, but movement to the side catches Catra's attention. When she looks up, she sees it.

"Quick, get down!" she hisses, grabbing Adora's shoulder and hauling her down from the path and into the undergrowth lining it.

"What? Catra- *mphg*!" Adora protests, words muffling as Catra slaps a hand over her mouth and pulls them into the safety of a bushy fern. The leaves aren't as soft as they look, sharp and scratchy against Catra's fur, but it hides them from sight as she tucks them both away. In the partial darkness, Adora blinks, stunned, and turns to send Catra a questioning look. At least she has gotten with the program and isn't trying to talk. In answer, Catra raises her hand and points out between the fern leaves, making sure she stays hidden. Adora turns to follow her point, eyes widening.

The lumbering shape of a giant creature is largely obscured by the overgrowth, but its mass can be seen as it makes its way the undergrowth. Suddenly the apparent trails in such a hidden part of the woods makes sense.

"Whoa," Adora breathes. The tip of Catra's tail flicks nervously as they watch it through the gaps in the ferns. "I've never seen an elemental like that," Adora whispers. Catra's ears twitch back, but the thing is pretty far, even if each of its steps reverberates through the ground. It's unlikely to hear them.

"If it even *is* an elemental. Who knows what is in this part of the woods," Catra whispers back, falling silent as the creature grows closer. They sit in tense silence as, slowly, it lumbers on, never

seeming to turn in their direction. Catra's heartrate starts calming down as its footsteps fade away, the woods falling silent again.

"I think it's safe," Adora says, but she whispers it, so her confidence doesn't seem high. Nevertheless, Adora takes Catra's hand and carefully pushes the ferns aside so they can rise from the bush. Catra's tail is still twitching and she makes sure to survey their surroundings for any *other* surprises, but they're left alone in unfamiliar woods again. Adora glances around herself before squeezing Catra's hand and pulling lightly on it.

"Come on, let's keep going. We're close," Adora promises, voice still low. Catra's tail lashes as she reluctantly follows.

"You don't know that! We could be about to wander into a den of those things," Catra hisses back. "Just because this is new doesn't mean it's *right*.

"What, are you scared to fight one?" Adora throws back, flashing Catra a grin. Catra scowls at her, feeling that itch rise beneath her fur that usually leads to her tackling Adora.

"Please, as if – but if *your* dumb ass gets hurt, both of us are going to get in trouble," Catra returns.

"Hey, *I* can take it!" Adora protests, and then to prove it, she lunges at Catra and tries to yank her into a headlock. Catra wrestles back, the two of them going tumbling through the undergrowth as they wrestle for supremacy. It's freedom, that tension beneath her skin releasing as Catra bites at Adora's hand to get her to yank it away and throw her off-balance.

Off-balance, and right down a hill. Catra hisses as twigs and leaves slap against her skin, the two of them coming to a halt at the base of the hill. Catra is on top, blinking down at Adora. For a moment, they just lay there, staring at each other, neither of them willing to start the wrestle again. It feels nice to be on top of her like this, winning, even if it was luck. Adora looks so pretty this close. Catra is just getting

lost in Adora's blue eyes when she notices they are fixed over her shoulder.

"Uh, Catra," Adora warns, trailing off as Catra whips her head around. There's nothing there – kind of.

A white glow is emanating from the woods, further in the direction they rolled in. Just barely, Catra can hear a kind of twinkling accompany the glow. Adora pushes on her shoulder and Catra reluctantly sits back, slowly rising to her feet, but no monster peaks out at her over the brush as Adora stands.

"That's it," Adora says, taking her hand again. The map is gone, lost somewhere in the tussling. Catra's tails lashes.

"We don't know that isn't some glowing monster," she hisses back. Glowing seems just as likely to be bad as it is good. It could even be the lights of some kind of Horde outpost no one knows about. Adora pushes leaves aside confidently, though, forging on.

"That's it," she reiterates, like it's *certain*. Catra's tail lashes as she follows behind Adora. If she's getting herself captured then Catra is going to be the one to save her.

"This is a weird magic thing, isn't it?" Catra asks Adora's swinging ponytail. It feels a lot like when Adora says where they're going to end up in the woods and then they're just *there*.

"No, just intuition," Adora insists.

It's totally a weird magic thing.

--

The sword looks almost exactly like Light Hope showed them, buried in the ground with vines surrounding it. There's just the *glowing* they weren't warned about.

"I think it's been doing that this whole time," Catra mutters, edging closer to the blade and inspecting it. It looks cool, but it's kind of bulky. Catra will take the maneuverability of her own claws, thanks. She glances back to find Adora standing at the edge of the clearing, struggling to stay where she's rooted as her eyes reflect the sword's sparkle.

"Probably not," she murmurs. Catra looks back to the sword, nerves rattling in her chest. This sounded easy on the surface, but now she's seeing the effect the sword is having on Adora, she isn't sure. In the corner of her eyes, she sees Adora's hand clenching on nothing, like she's imagining taking the hilt.

What if Light Hope lied? What if Adora touches the sword and she's just gone, replaced by She-ra? It's glowing, beckoning to them. That's Grade A trap stuff.

Adora sways forward and Catra makes a decision, reaching for the hilt. If it's a trap, she'll be the one to spring it, and if it's not, Light Hope doesn't want Adora to have the sword yet anyway. She'll probably lock it up somewhere where it can't enchant Adora. Razz talks about Adora as if she was her own person outside of She-ra, right? It will be fine.

The handle is unyielding beneath her hand. She tries to pull on the sword and nothing happens. Frowning, she braces herself on the ground, wrapping both hands around it and pulling as hard as she can. All she does is strain for several seconds.

"You've *got* to be kidding me," Catra mutters to herself, standing back to survey the sword.

"Is it stuck?" Adora calls from the edge of the clearing, sounding unsure. Catra squats, inspecting the base of the sword. Only the tip

is stuck in the ground. The vines, thick as roots, are the main thing holding it in place. Catra slides her claws out.

"Pretty sure it's another weird magic thing," Catra throws back over her shoulder as she slashes down through a root. It's tough, but so is Catra and it gives beneath her claws.

As soon as she cuts through it, the severed base grows to reconnect with its dangling upper half. Before Catra can even pull back, another root grows out of the ground and wraps up the sword's blade in response.

"Of course it's not going to be easy. Why would we just be able to pick up an old sword?" Catra asks, turning to glare over her shoulder at Adora. Adora raises her hands.

"Hey, *I'm* not doing it!" she protests as Catra scoffs and looks back to the sword. No, but it is her dumb magic destiny. Catra pokes at the blade. Nothing happens. She tries to pull on the handle again, but she doesnt make any progress. The roots are only wrapped around the blade – if anything the blade should be easy to slide out, cutting them as it goes – but somehow their grip is stronger than titanium.

"Pretty sure I have one shot at this," she warns. Adora startles in the edge of her vision, starting forward and walking a bit around the edge of the clearing so she can see Catra's face where she stands.

"What are you going to do?" she asks, sounding anxious. Catra just shakes her head, rising into a ready stance. Knowing the Whispering Woods, saying it out loud would *warn* them and they would pre-emptively ruin her plan.

"Just stay back," she warns, worried about cutting Adora accidentally more than anything. She takes a deep breath and then she lets loose, frantically swiping her claws, trying to cut through all the roots at once. If they all severed, she might be able to pull it free before they regrew, but there's so many of them. As soon as she cuts one, more grow to its place. By the time she has cut that, the original has

regrown and *another* new one has joined it. She lets loose in a fury, slashing as fast as she can and then tugging at the handle when she realizes it's a losing cause, but at the end she's just standing there, panting, the base of her claws numbly pulsing and the blade covered in roots.

"You made it worse," Adora observes from the side. Catra jerks her head up, glaring at her, and Adora raises her hands in apology.

"*Tch*," Catra dismisses, growling to herself as she looks down at the sword again. Okay, they need a new plan.

She doesn't have one.

--

"Maybe there's something we have to do to get the woods to let it go?" Adora suggests from the side. Catra groans and throws an arm over her eyes. She's sprawled out beside the sword, which sits inert in the tangle of roots again. She has tried yanking on it, and lightly slicing the roots so they don't sever completely, but instead of weakening them so she could pull the sword free, they just healed. And then a new root joined them. Because of course it did.

"You want to have a conversation with it? Fine, you try. The woods don't listen to me," Catra returns. She's pretty sure they *both* know what the solution is, but if Adora has to be the one to pull the sword free, then they're just going to have to leave it for a few years. The woods are protecting it on their own just fine, clearly. It they have to leave it anyway, maybe they can go get fire or something and try that on the roots. It would certainly be more fun.

Catra listens as Adora edges closer, entering the clearing properly and stopping between Catra and the sword. Catra peaks out from

under her arm as Adora swats down and gives an unsure *wave* to the sword. She's so stupid. It's adorable.

"Um, hi, Sword of Protection. Or , Whispering Woods, I guess? Whichever one of you is doing.this,"Adora gestures at the roots as if *either* of her supposed audiences have eyes. Catra sits up just for a better view of the awkward show. "I'm Adora, the new She-ra. Catra is my friend, and she's trying to bring the sword to safety for me, so could you maybe let it go?"

A mild breeze stirs the leaves around them, and for a second Catra thinks something might actually be about to happen, but then it falls quiet again and they're just staring at a shimmering blade.

"So, any other ideas?"Catra asks, rolling her eyes. Adora huf fs, looking over her shoulder to pout at Catra.

"W ell, at least *try* pulling it now,"she says. Catra snorts, but she stands, brushing her hands off and walking over to the sword. Predictably, when she tries to pull on it, nothing happens.

"Okay , come on. I know you're probably trying to keep the sword safe, but out here *isn't* safe,"Adora tries, opening negotiations with the magic forest, apparently. She keeps going, but Catra senses *something* unsettling and her ears twitch, drowning out the sound of Adora's voice as she listens intently. Another shiver runs through her and this time she realizes it's *real* – and quickly building.

"Adora, shut up,"Catra hisses, making a shooshing motion with her hand as she swivels her ears around, trying to track the source of the movement. It's probably another elemental and all they need is to duck out of sight, but they need to know where to hide.

It's also moving a *lot* faster than the last one, Adora's eyes going wide as the ground begins to tremble. Catra hears the sound of underbrush moving and whips around, spotting the giant shape looming in the distance – and sprinting straight for them.

"Great plan, Adora!" Catra says, readying her claws as the *thing*, some kind of giant bug with murder in its many eyes, breaches the clearing.

"I didn't think it would have a *security system*," Adora shoots back, reaching for the retractable staff resting at her back and clicking it out. Catra would say something snarky, but she's kind of busy leaping for the trees as the bug lunges at her. Her claws catch the bark and she scrambles up, climbing to the high branches as the bug tries to snap at her from below. Adora runs at it from the ground, using the staff as a vault and landing a heavy kick against its side, but it only stumbles, remaining focused. Blunt attacks aren't going to do anything against its carapace, apparently, so their best bet is Catra leaping on it from above and using her claws on one of the cracks between segments, but she can't do that when there's gaping mandibles waiting to bite her in half, a dozen glowing eyes fixed on her.

The bug looks down, and for a second Catra thinks it's her opening, but then the entire tree shakes as the bug starts chewing into the trunk with its mandibles, gnawing deep gashes into the tree within seconds. Catra scrambles, barely hanging on with her claws as the branches shake. Adora tries to wedge her staff in one of the segment gaps, but the staff is too wide to get beneath them and just glances off. Catra is going to have to leap for it, but she can't get a good launch with the entire tree shaking it.

"Adora!" she yells, hoping for any distraction that can give her the opening to jump and pierce its eyes or something.

"I'm trying!" Adora yells back, wailing on it with her staff, but the blunt hits do nothing.

A loud *crack* echoes as the bug snaps through the trunk, the entire tree lurching to the side. Catra scrambles, barely managing to push off and catch her claws on the trunk beside her, scrambling up again. The bug immediately runs for her, but Catra is prepared this time, and she launches before it begins to chew through the tree. She

lands on its back in the center of one of its segments, scrambling to dig her claws into the smooth surface. She catches on, the bug whipping around searching for her, but even when her claws pierce its exoskeleton, they dont dig deep enough to hurt it or make it back off.

And now it's turning on Adora, the only visible target left. Adora yells, raising her staff in time to block its snapping mandibles. Catra scrambles up its shell, trying to find a seam to rip up, but the carapace just cracks off in small pieces, revealing only slightly softer flesh. It has to be enough. Catra dives in with her claws, feeling something wet burst. The creature roars, snapping Adora's staff in *half* as it does.

Adora scrambles back, falling at the base of the vine tangle as she does. Catra desperately tries to slice further into the bug, but it charges forward at Adora.

"I'm sorry!" Adora calls, and before Catra can ask what that means, she's scrambling up and grabbing the sword's hilt. "For the honor of Grayskull!" she yells, a phrase that chills Catra to her bone.

A flash of light takes over the clearing, blinding Catra. The bug lurches back and she has to scramble to latch on again. As she blinks the light away from her eyes, a glowing form takes shape standing in front of the bug. The bug, like Catra, is frozen, staring at the form in front of it.

It's Adora, only twice as tall, lanky with hair billowing behind her like a golden cape – which matches her *actual* cape whipping around her shoulders in an invisible wind, her clothes replaced with a white-and-gold unitard. She glares down at the bug, her face both familiar and new, set in stone.

The blue glow of the bug's eyes dies as slowly it lowers itself to the ground, mandibles going slack. Docile. Catra pants from its top, looking down at her claws covered in blue bug-goo and grimacing. She braces herself on her hands and leaps off the bug, trying to land

beside it as quietly as possible, but the bug doesn't grow aggressive again. Instead, it turns and lumbers back into the woods, showing no interest in them. Catra straightens, still panting, and turns to Adora.

"Adora?" she asks. Adora turns to her, face appearing emotionless. Catra's ears pin back. "Adora?" she tries again, her voice quieter and more fearful. Adora's eyes widen, recognition lighting in them, and then in another flash, She-ra is gone, Adora back to her regular size and swaying on her feet.

"Adora!" Catra shouts, lunging for her and catching her before she can fall to the ground. The sword slips through Adora's fingers and hits the forest floor as Adora groans, stirring vaguely in her arms. Luckily, vines don't grow around it again. Adora manages a few heavy breaths before bracing her hands on Catra's shoulders and pushing herself back to her feet. She blinks, the haze from her eyes clearing.

"Catra? Are you okay?" she asks, her voice a little shaky. Catra swallows, nodding.

"Are you?" she asks. That wasn't what she was expecting when Adora finally *claimed her destiny* or whatever.

"Yeah, I'm... that was a *lot*. I wasn't expecting it to feel like that," Adora tells her, gaze dragging over Catra to check for injuries and then catching on the sword on the ground. Catra quickly bends down, snatching it up before Adora can touch it again.

"Let's just get out of here," Catra says, glancing around for any other signs of monsters, but they seem to be alone now, only the odd tangle of roots and felled tree left to signal what happened here. Adora's eyes linger on the sword pressed tightly against Catra's chest for a minute, but then she nods.

Catra blows out a steady breath. She is *so* ready to go home and chuck this into a locker.

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They don't speak much until they're out of the deep woods. Somehow, they get spit out not far from the Crystal Castle despite how far they must have been from it.

"Weird magic stuff," Catra mutters to herself, petulantly, as she clutches the sword close to her chest. It hasn't seemed to have any effect on Adora since she made the connection, but Catra is feeling a bit paranoid. Adora shrugs, sending Catra an apologetic look.

"At least it's not much further. We can get cleaned up and rest knowing it's safe," she promises. Adora isn't that dirty, but Catra still has bug blood on her claws and bits of twigs and leaves – plus whatever else shook out of that tree – in her hair. She desperately needs a shower.

"But are *you*?" Catra asks, her hand tightening on the hilt. Adora startles, turning to look at her, but Catra keeps walking.

"Catra? I'm fine, I promise," Adora tries, her voice cautious. Catra shakes her head, finally drawing to a halt.

"You were *weird*, Adora. She-ra didn't act like you. She didn't even *look* like you," Catra says, shooting Adora a desperate look. Adora's mouth falls open in an *o*. After a moment, she rallies, reaching her hand out to Catra with the palm up.

"Give me the sword," she says. Catra hisses, jerking back and clutching tighter.

"No! Light Hope said it was dangerous and for once I agree with her," Catra refuses. Adora shakes her head, just reaching her hand out again.

"It was dangerous because I would form my connection with She-ra the moment I touched it. That's already happened. You know I wont transform without the passphrase now. As long as I dont say , you know, the *thing*, it will be fine," Adora reasons. Catra doesnt loosen her grip on the sword.

"You looked through me," she says. Adora' s eyes widen, like they did only several seconds after they landed on Catra when Adora was She-ra. Adora lowers her hand slowly and that's the only reason Catra lets her take a step closer without darting back.

"It wasnt like that. I was in battle mode. You werent a threat – because youre *you*, youd never hurt me – so I didnt react. I knew you," Adora promises, her voice low . It makes Catra feel slightly better to hear, but that is *not* what it looked like.

"I watched you recognize me," Catra says, her voice wary . Adora's brow pinches.

"I wasnt recognizing *you*, I was recognizing fear. Like I said, I was in battle mode. It was like all the noise fell away when I transformed and I knew what to do, but when it was all done and you looked scared, that became all that mattered. I needed *me*, not She-ra, so I let her go. She was so strong that when she left, I suddenly felt weak in comparison and that's why I almost fainted," Adora explains, waving her hands.

"Adora. Stupid magic stuff," Catra corrects. Adora huffs a laugh, rolling her eyes.

"I was seeing you scared and realizing there was something more important than fighting a bug that was already leaving anyway. Give me the sword so I can prove it?" Adora summarizes, holding her hand out again. Catra eyes it. That makes sense to her, but she's still wary.

"I wont transform. Im fine, Catra. You know the main reason Light Hope doesnt want me being She-ra yet is because she thinks Im

just too young to succeed. Im not going to blow up,"Adora promises. Catra huffs, but reluctantly she unfurls her arms from her chest to reveal the sword. Adora gives her an encouraging smile, taking a step to meet her halfway.

Her hand closes over the pommel, and nothing happens.

"See?"Adora says, gently slipping her fingers between Catra' s on the hilt to hold it alongside her. Catra feels her cheeks heat. She huffs as she lets go of the sword and lets Adora heft it, instinct seeming to take over. She shifts into the default stance she uses when training with her regular sword, though she holds the sword lower than usual, glancing down at the blade. "It' s heavier than I thought it would be,"she admits.

Catra cant help it;she laughs. It' s a mixof relief and amusement at what a dork Adora is.

"Idiot,"she accuses, voice soft. Adora looks up, flashing her a grin, before looking back down at the sword and turning it over in her hand to look down at the runestone in its hilt. Catra feels a bit of uncertainty enter her heart again, just waiting for something to happen, but all that does is Adora tilting the sword so the runestone catches the light and shines.

"It didnt feel how I thought it would,"Adora admits. Catra' s tail twitches. She has wondered about that too, but she knew she would never get a real answer. She isnt magic. She' s never going to be. Adora's descriptions will always be meaningless to her.

"What was it like?"she asks. Adora frowns as she thinks it over .

"W arm? Like an adrenaline rush, kind of. I thought Id felt magic before, but that was different. It didnt feel dangerous like I worried. It made me feel *good*, like I could finally do something. It felt like that moment when you conqer a new move that has been giving you trouble, and suddenly you know youre better than you were before and there's new possibilities,"Adora explains, finally lowering the

sword and looking to Catra as if she expects to see recognition in her eyes. Catra just barely understands the end of that example, but she feels a jealous pang in her chest that she pushes down.

"As long as you don't let all that power go to your head," she says, settling for elbowing Adora and turning back towards the castle. Adora skips forward to fall in line beside her, rolling her eyes and opening her mouth – probably to say something sarcastic – but Catra interrupts her by snatching the sword out of her hands.

"Hey!" Adora protests, reaching for it again, but Catra dances a few steps back, sending Adora a flat look.

"If Light Hope sees you holding this, we're *both* in trouble," Catra says. Adora's eyes go wide as she clearly realizes for the first time that they're screwed.

"She already knows," Adora says, to herself as much as Catra. Catra rolls her eyes.

"No *duh*. She doesn't need to know I let you touch it again, though," Catra points out. Light Hope always knows everything. She's somehow connected to the sword too, so the chances she missed She-ra appearing are almost zero even before you figure in the scanner she has monitoring spikes of power around the planet.

"I'm the one who did it. You weren't in a position to stop me. Besides, it was fine. Nothing blew up and we made it out," Adora assures herself – herself, because Catra isn't that naïve. She snorts.

"Sure," she agrees. They're so getting yelled at.

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Catra was expecting the lecture about how dangerous that was. She was expecting to get blamed for letting Adora touch the sword. She was even expecting Adora to defend her to Light Hope. She wasn't expecting anything she said to make a *difference*.

"When I tried to fight that thing by myself, I did *nothing*. Catra was the only one who did any damage to it. I would have been helpless without her or She-ra," Adora says, gesturing down to Catra's hands, still stained from digging into the bug's back. Catra curls them into fists, feeling strangely self-conscious. Maybe it's just how small these *you're not good enough, neither of you are, push each other harder* talks make her feel.

"It didn't need fighting, it needed calming. She-ra must approach things with tactics and thought, not just brute force," Light Hope returns. Adora throws her hands up.

"And I couldn't have calmed it without She-ra! How is it Catra's fault I needed to transform?" Adora demands. Catra isn't sure why she's surprised at this point. There's always a way to place blame when something goes wrong. With a mission like this, there was no way it was going to go off without a hitch. Adora has gotten her scolding, but at least it was only for things she did. Now Catra is getting blamed for them too, because just like there's always blame, it always applies to *both* of them somehow.

"If Catra weren't there, that thing would have run me over before I could pull out the sword. The only reason She-ra is safe now – the sword *or me* – is because Catra was here. She fought hard today. I made my own choices, and I maintain that it was the right call. You already admitted it yourself," Adora says, reaching over and grabbing Catra's shoulders, curling around her protectively. Despite herself, a low purr starts in Catra's chest.

She doesn't expect Light Hope to change her mind, but all she has ever really needed was Adora's approval. To her surprise, after a moment Light Hope looks between them and softens from the stiff height she pulls herself up to when chastising them. The main

difference is she inclines her head forward – although Catra *swears* she shrinks an inch or two – but it's still a signal they know even without Light Hope having a true body to project language.

"Things went wrong, but the mission was a success. We will see if this early connection has negative consequences when it is time for you to take up the sword, but for now, you should rest," Light Hope acquiesces. Catra lets out a breath of relief. It's good enough for her. Adora's arm tightens around her, and for a moment Catra thinks she's going to keep arguing – Adora loves to argue, all three of them do, it has led to some truly incredible fights – but then she smiles, nodding as she hugs Catra sideways.

They turn, ready to retreat to their hidden room now Light Hope has taken the sword into her archives, but they're stopped by Light Hope's voice.

"Catra," she says. They both freeze, exchanging a look, and then turn back around.

"Both of you: you brought us one step closer to finally facing the Horde and balancing the planet again today. Well done," Light Hope praises. Catra sucks in a breath, her chest feeling lighter with it. No matter how much blame goes around, praise from Light Hope feels special. It *means* something, causing both of them to straighten and nod gratefully.

When they walk away this time, there's a lot less tension.

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There have apparently been a few small bugs in Catra's hair for *hours*, but she finally feels clean after a shower despite her usual distaste for them. They're uncomfortable when she doesn't have

anything designed for magicats. Sometimes the villagers will give them things, so Catra has known the luxury of proper fur conditioners before and it made all the difference, but everything in the castle was made for First Ones. Most of the time Catra just reluctantly hurries through a shower using Adora's products.

This place wasn't built for her. It's a whole castle just for Adora. Catra's place here has been carved out with her claws and Adora's tenacity. When she emerges from her bathroom into their room – She-ra's room, hidden inside a wall with a secret window that allows view of the castle's central chamber – Adora is splayed out in their bed, the sheet already pulled aside exactly where Catra likes to curl up. She quickly takes the invitation, curling up into a ball in the familiar spot her fur already clings to. A moment later, Adora drapes the blanket over her and nestles up beside her, wrapping her arms around her.

"Our first mission was a success," she murmurs, burying her face in Catra's shoulder and then immediately pulling back when she just gets a face full of wet hair. Catra snorts, turning over so they're face-to-face and Adora doesn't have to deal with how impossible it is to dry her mane.

"A success we got yelled at for," Catra amends. Adora pouts. It's cute. Catra rolls her eyes so she'll be forced to look away, burying her face down in the pillow and breathing deep. It's covered in their mixed scents, a safe hideaway from the world above – from the war, from their looming responsibilities, from the creatures in the woods, and from Light Hope, even, with no sensors inside this room.

Adora reaches out, petting Catra's – mostly dried – ears.

"She changed her mind and we got the sword. We *won* our first real battle," Adora says. Reluctantly, Catra purrs to herself. It's the pets, really.

"We *are* pretty cool," she agrees. Adora giggles, butting forward to rub their faces together, nuzzling Catra's cheek. Catra rumbles,

nuzzling back and marking Adora’s face. Hers. Adora turned into She-ra for the first time today, but she didnt suddenly decide that she doesnt need Catra anymore like she has feared. She *defended* Catra to Light Hope. As long as theyre together , the war doesnt scare Catra. The only thing she cares about is keeping Adora. She-ra didnt suddenly make her charge of f without her. It will be okay.

Adora’s destiny is waiting, but theyll face it together .

End Notes

(I know bugs don't have "blood," but Catra doesn't.)
This is kind of a "happy childhood" AU, but also Light Hope has just as much of an agenda as Shadow Weaver, she's just nicer 😅 They're both going to end up with similar baggage to what Shadow Weaver gave them, it's just going to be less painful along the way.

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